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Government: Passage of a state bill boosts free legal aid for low-income renters in the area

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The pot of state money to pay for free legal services for low-income people just got a funding boost that is projected to amount to $110 million over a 10-year-period, under a state bill signed into law by Gov. Gavin Newsom last week.

The additional dollars for pro-bono legal services could go to help San Fernando Valley residents facing evictions, as well as prevent people from being pushed into homelessness, according to Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, one of the authors of the funding legislation, known as Assembly Bill 330.

People who have legal representation tend to reach settlements more often than those who repre

sent themselves. Having evictions on their record or credit histories often makes it harder for people to get accepted for another rental, increasing the chances of homelessness, according to a state fact sheet on the program.

Gabriel said that while a study commissioned by the state found the pilot programs were effective in reducing evictions and homelessness, there is still a large “unmet demand” among low-income people who need help defending themselves in eviction proceedings.

“I think it’s going to help a lot of people in need,” he said.

“One of the fundamental tenets of our legal system is that everybody should have equal access to justice,” he said, but that is often “not the reality.”

Neighborhood Legal Services of Los Angeles County, which has an office in Pacoima, was one of the organizations that is already receiving funding for a pilot program that offers legal services to people facing evictions. In 2014, the organization provided legal representation on nearly 1,400 cases, and other kinds of legal assistance on a little 1,800 cases, according to the state-commissioned study.

Yvonne Mariajimenez, executive director of Neighborhood Legal Services of Los Angeles County, said the extra funding means “the legal services community can expand our capacity to protect our clients’ fundamental human right to housing and keep more of our clients from falling into homelessness.”

The bill raises court filing fees by $15 starting January 2020 to pay for the legal service provided through the Sargent Shriver Civil Counsel Act, which provides grants to legal aid organizations helping low-income people who are defending themselves in housing and evictions related cases, as well as those having to do with child-custody, domestic violence, and applications for guardianship and conservatorship.

The added fees is projected to boost the annual $7 million in revenue for the Shriver programs to $19 million a year, which is a $110 million increase over the span of a decade, Gabriel said.

The Shriver program was created in 2009 through a bill authored by then-Assemblyman Mike Feuer, who is now serving as Los Angeles’s City Attorney. Grants are awarded competitively, with recommendations made by a state committee.

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